

SPIRIT OF THE SOIL

Firmly rooted in the soil of Bangladesh, a brilliant first novel tells the tale of two nations that became three



A GOLDEN AGE
by TAHMINA ANAM
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■ By Brinda Bose

Dear husband, I lost our children today." The opening sentence of Tahmina Anam's debut novel *A Golden Age* is absorbing enough for us to forgive its clichéd title (which is rather more reminiscent of history lessons on the Gupta kings than the nostalgic evocation of a golden East Pakistan/Bengal). The novel, however, is just as poignant as its first sentence. The widowed Rehana talks to her husband at his graveside on every pivotal occasion in her lonely, dignified life: today, in a Dhaka court, she has lost the custody of their young children Sohail and Maya to her husband's brother Faiz, who will take them away to Lahore far across Indian terrains, to bring them up better. The judge has agreed that she is unfit to raise them because she has not yet come to terms with her husband's death, because she is too young and too poor, and because she has taken the children to see *Cleopatra*.

When the novel reopens in the second section, Rehana's children are grown up. She is in the habit of organising a party every year to mark the day long ago when she retrieved them from Lahore and brought them home again to Dhaka. Their country is still East Pakistan, on the brink of a new identity which they will find only at the cost of a very bloody war in 1971. The university-going Sohail and Maya are caught up in the revolutionary struggle for a free *shonar* Bangla, while Rehana, cautiously patriotic and overwhelmingly maternal, fears that she will lose her children all over again—and this time to a cause she cannot wrestle.

Anam has been hailed as the new Monica Ali of South Asian fiction, but besides sharing a Bangladeshi origin

and a current residency in Britain, there is very little in common between the two. There is, instead, a vital difference in their respective "Bangladeshi" novels, which Anam has been quick to point out. *A Golden Age* is the middle novel of a trilogy, the writer has quixotically suggested, and she says that she will now go back to write the first (which will be set during the Partition of Bengal). It digs firmly, and deeply, into the rich alluvium of her *desh* *mati* to tell a gruesome war tale, the tale of two nations that became three in the span of a crucial quarter-century of

from Rehana's story of the cries for a beloved new country, of guns and riots, the aggression of the army and the spilling of young blood, as much as of the smaller, inconspicuous but no less terrifying trials of life—struggling, taking, giving, and loving, expectedly and unexpectedly, covertly and passionately.

Anam was born in a nascent Bangladesh in the mid-1970s, but grew up in Paris, New York and Bangkok, and completed her academic career with a doctorate in social anthropology from Harvard. She speaks "American", if we are to go by

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subcontinental history.

She chooses to tell this story through the prism of a single family, a fatherless one. Rehana's relationships with her children, and her land—especially the house "with its back to the sun" that she builds in her enormous backyard and names Shona for it is her wealth, her gold in brick and mortar—narrate to us the loves and the fears, the dreams and the magic, the terror and the trauma, of losing some to gain some. We learn

accents. But *A Golden Age* is possibly as "Bangladeshi" as any novel in Bangla about the 1971 war—and this is perhaps the greatest tribute one can pay to Anam. In stylish prose interspersed effectively with choppy cadences, this novel is as searing in its pain as it is wrenching in its passion and scorching in its honesty. The author may speak like a New Yorker and adopt London as her residence, but it is Bangladesh that she has done proud with her first work of fiction. ■